

musically conservative father would not allow him to hear anything but the Austro-German classics. Wagner was beyond the pale. After composing his first song at the age of six, Strauss continued to write songs modeled on Schubert and Schumann, encouraged by his father and his flamboyant aunt Johanna, a talented mezzo-soprano.

A crucial moment in Strauss's teens was his discovery of Wagner's *Tristan und Isolde*. Defying his father's orders, he devoured the score "in a trance" and became a lifelong Wagnerian—though not yet in his own music. Before he was 20 he had composed fluent instrumental works modeled largely on Mozart, Beethoven, and Mendelssohn, including two symphonies and an ebullient horn concerto. At 21, Strauss published his first truly original set of songs, including the soaring "Zueignung."



PAGE FROM *TRISTAN UND ISOLDE*

Strauss described the final bars of Wagner's opera *Tristan und Isolde* as "the most beautifully orchestrated B-major chord in the history of music."